

Education and Training Sector External Service Delivery Plan 2014 - 2016

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1. Introduction

The Government's Public Service Reform Plan, published in November 2011, sets out five major commitments to change as follows:

- Placing customer service at the core of everything we do
- Strong focus on implementation and delivery
- Maximising new and innovative service delivery channels
- Leading, organising and working in new ways
- Radically reducing our costs to drive better value for money

The Government mandate for the implementation of shared services and external service delivery is very clear and comes directly from Government policy as articulated in the Programme for Government and in the Public Service Reform Plan. Public funded bodies across the Education and Training sector will be required to participate in shared service initiatives undertaken across the sector and in the schools, further education and training and higher education sub-sectors. It is also now mandatory for all Departments to consider the costs and benefits of delivering existing and new services using external providers.

We aim to deliver centralised and outsourced services where these are supported by a strong business case.

1.1 Vision for Shared Services & External Service Delivery

In line with Government policy, shared services and external service delivery models will be core elements of the Education and Training Sector Reform Programme. The purpose of implementing these delivery models is to deliver cost savings, efficiencies and other benefits to enable resources to be focused on service delivery.

The mission is to deliver value and benefits to our customers in the Education and Training Sector through:-

- Customer relationships that are built on quality of service
- People who are skilled, dedicated and enjoy what they do
- Technology that is leading edge
- Optimised business processes
- Focus on delivery of results and continuous improvement

To ensure that this is achieved we have identified a number of design principles that will underpin our approach to shared services and external service delivery:

- Initiatives will be based on robust data (baselining)
- Initiatives will, where feasible, be cross sector / sub-sectors to bring scale
- Existing initiatives/infrastructure will be leveraged to the maximum extent possible (subject to business case)
- The focus will be on administrative and corporate processes, but opportunities for smaller scale centres of excellence will also be considered
- The autonomy of all institutions will be respected (including data confidentiality)
- Options assessment will consider all valid scenarios from do nothing through to shared services and outsourcing
- Options assessment will consider risk assessment and risk management

1.2 Governance Structures

In line with the Government's Public Service Reform Plan, external service delivery and shared services must be considered by all public bodies. In addition, Government has mandated that an external service delivery plan and a shared service plan be prepared by each of the four main sectoral Departments (Health, Education, Local Government and Justice).

Robust governance arrangements have been put in place to drive, manage and monitor implementation of the reform programme across the Education and Training Sector. An overarching Education and Training Reform Board has been established and is chaired by the Secretary General. A dedicated Programme Management Office (PMO) has been established to drive the implementation of the reform plan including the use of external service delivery models. The PMO is the central, overarching, co-ordination function for Education and Training reform. A fulltime Programme Manager and Shared Service Adviser have been recruited.

The PMO reports to the Education and Training Reform Board, comprising:

- Seán Ó Foghlú, Secretary General, Chair
- Peter Baldwin, Assistant Secretary General
- Pat Burke, Assistant Secretary General
- Ruth Carmody, Assistant Secretary General
- Mary Doyle, Deputy Secretary General
- Michael Keogh, Assistant Secretary General
- Martin Hanevy, Assistant Secretary General

Given the scale and diversity of the Education and Training Sector, two sub-sectoral governance structures have been put in place for the ETB/SOLAS and Higher Education sectors.

The ETB/SOLAS Programme Board is also chaired by the Secretary General and comprises the following membership:

- Seán Ó Foghlú, Secretary General, Chair
- Peter Baldwin, Assistant Secretary General
- Pat Burke, Assistant Secretary General
- Ruth Carmody, Assistant Secretary General
- Michael Keogh, Assistant Secretary General
- Martin Hanevy, Assistant Secretary General
- Michael Moriarty, General Secretary, Education and Training Boards Ireland
- David Leahy, CEO, Galway Roscommon Education and Training Board
- Paddy Lavelle, CEO, Dublin Dun Laoghaire Education and Training Board
- Paul O'Toole, CEO, SOLAS

A dedicated project office has been established to lead on the ETB/SOLAS project with a full time programme manager assigned at Principal Officer level and an ETB / SOLAS Programme Board currently chaired by the Secretary General.

A Higher Education Reform Programme Board has been established and is chaired by Mary Doyle, Deputy Secretary General with responsibility for Higher Education. This board will oversee the implementation of this plan in the higher education sector. The Board has the following membership:

- Mary Doyle, Deputy Secretary General, Chair
- Ruth Carmody, Assistant Secretary General
- Christy Mannion, Principal Officer, Higher Education Research and Finance
- Michael Casey, Director, Finance and Operations, Irish Universities Association
- Ian Mathews, Treasurer, Trinity College Dublin
- Gearoid Hodgins, Director of HR/IR, Institutes of Technology Ireland
- Brian Norton, President, Dublin Institute of Technology

1.3 Implementation

Progress of the external delivery of service agenda within the Education and Training sector is being led by the PMO and related governance structures that are now in place. The PMO will be responsible for the implementation of this External Service Delivery Plan commencing in Q1 2014.

2. Department and Agencies

2.1 Introduction and context

The Department's role is to support the educational success of each learner and to drive improvements in the overall performance of the education and training system. We must also ensure that we deliver our day-to-day services efficiently and effectively.

The Department carries out a wide range of activities at all levels of the education and training system, working in collaboration with a number of national agencies. These activities includes policy development; providing funding, services and support for education providers; planning and providing education and training infrastructure and enhancing education and training through co-operation on a North-South basis and through involvement in the activities of the European Union (EU) and other international agencies.

The Department has also been mandated with a specific role in relation to the Residential Institutions Redress and a number of related bodies operate under the aegis of the Department.

The Department works with a number of specialist agencies in the sector and these are listed in Appendix 1 to this document.

2.2 Operating Environment

The cost of running the Department (including the National Educational Psychological Service) accounted for approximately €89.4m in 2013 or about 1% of the total allocation for the education and training sector.

The Department's administrative budget has reduced from €97 million (spend) in 2009 to €89.4 (allocation) in 2013. This represents a drop of 8%. Some allocations have reduced by more, for instance the overall pay allocation has reduced by 9%, travel and subsistence by 20% and the regional office service by 100%. Overtime pay accounts for about 1% of our total pay allocation (€630,000 in 2012).

The Department's staff (including school inspectors) reduced by 121 or 10.5% between March 2009 and December 2012 and there has been no internal promotions in the Department since March 2009.

Despite these challenges, the Department's staff and agencies are leading on an extensive programme of reform across the education and training. This reform programme centres around four key themes:

Learning for Life

We want an education and training system that provides all learners with the knowledge and skills they need to participate fully in society and the economy, one that enables learners to learn how to learn.

Improving Quality and Accountability

We want an education and training system that provides high quality education and training experiences for everyone.

Supporting Inclusion and Diversity

We want an education and training system that welcomes and meaningfully includes learners with disabilities and special educational needs and those with language, cultural and social differences and supports disadvantaged learners.

Building the Right Systems and Infrastructure

We want a modern, flexible education and training system which makes the best use of available resources.

Shared Services and external service delivery models are being progressed in the context of the overall reform plan for the sector.

3. External Service Delivery in the Education and Training Sector

The Education and Training Sector has a long and successful track record in the use of external service delivery models. Some of the services and projects delivered through external service delivery are:

- School and higher education infrastructure design, construction and maintenance which also includes a number of Public Private Partnership arrangements;

- Education and training courses in the further education and training sector and the Higher Education sector;
- An Employee Assistance Service for Teachers and Special Needs Assistants and their families;
- School transport services;
- Back office and corporate service type functions such as ICT support, payroll, audit, legal services, waste management, security and cleaning in various education providers and agencies.

A list of current outsourcing in the sector is provided at Appendix 2.

3.1 External Service Delivery Projects Identified for Consideration

The objective now is to identify further non-core activities which may be suitable for external service delivery (ESD) to increase efficiency and productivity and to improve processes in the education and training sector. Following consultation with the relevant policy units across the Department a number of areas have been identified as having potential for ESD and these will be further examined.

3.2 Facilities Management

Across the schools sector and in many of the larger institutions in the higher education sector a number of facilities management services are currently being delivered by external providers. A number of the universities, for example, have already outsourced cleaning services, buildings maintenance services and security services and the spend on these services is €10.3 million, €3.6 million and €3.2 million respectively per annum. However, it is possible that there is scope across the education and training sector for further outsourcing in this area. We will assess the potential for further outsourcing, on a phased basis, commencing in Q1 2014 and as a first step we will conduct an audit of the facilities management services that are currently outsourced across the education and training sector. This will inform the identification of suitable projects and areas for further work. We will identify priority areas for progression by end Q2 2014.

3.3 Financial Control checks on European Social Fund (ESF) expenditure in the Further Education, FAS and Higher Education sectors

The cascade structure for European Social Fund (ESF) management and control was originally approved by the European Commission for the period 2007-2013. It is based upon a series of

levels of checks where assurance at each level is based to a large extent on the checks carried out at the level/s below. In this structure, the National ESF Authorities, namely the Audit, Certifying and Managing Authorities, are located within this Department and have responsibilities over the €375m ESF monies allocated to Ireland for 2007-2013 period. In addition, the Intermediate Bodies for FÁS/SOLAS, further education and higher education are also currently located within the Department and has delegated roles and responsibilities for 89% (€333m) of the total ESF allocation.

European Commission requirements for financial checks

The system of checking applied by the ESF Intermediates Bodies under the Irish cascade system was deemed acceptable by the European Commission and the Audit Authority when it was assessed in 2006 as part of the official Compliance Assessment process for the 2007-2013 period. Claims have been paid by the Commission for a number of years on foot of this assessment. However, the Commission have now changed their position in light of their recent audit work and that of the Audit Authority. This reflects a more general shift in attitude by EU auditors in relation to the Structural Funds in recent years following on from a decision to take a stronger, less flexible line in dealing with audit findings. This arises from the difficulties in having the EU Budget signed off by the European Court of Auditors and the high error rates on the Funds in general.

Checks within the current ESF system unsatisfactory

While the Irish ESF cascade architecture remains valid, it is clear that the work undertaken by the relevant players in the cascade needs to be reviewed and strengthened to meet the concerns raised by the auditors. Any enhanced structure will need to demonstrate an increased level of checks and an increased volume that includes checks during the operational period when the expenditure is actually happening on the ground. It will also have to be able to facilitate revised structures in the training and further education management space that are arising from and will continue to arise from the transformation to the new SOLAS and Education and Training Board (ETB) system. The role and functions of the ESF Certifying Authority and Audit Authority will remain the same for the remainder of the 2007-2013 period. But the 2014-2020 period will impose changes to the current structure and these may require additional resources once the full implications are assessed and quantified in practice.

The potential to outsource all of the financial checks that will be required to a single professional auditing body for the entire seven year period (2014 – 2020) will be assessed by the Department once the final ESF cascade structure is agreed.

3.4 Administration of Inspectorate Questionnaires

The Department's Inspectorate deploys questionnaires to parents and students at both primary and post-primary levels as part of the system of whole-school type evaluations. Other questionnaires are also in use by the Inspectorate on an ad-hoc basis. These are developed according to specific project needs and are deployed for short-burst activities. Approximately 47,000 questionnaires are administered annually by the Inspectorate. While responsibility for the administration of the questionnaires in schools would continue to be conducted by Inspectors, there is potential to outsource other related processes including managing the stock of questionnaires, the supply of questionnaires and the processing and analysis of completed questionnaires. In Q1 2014 we will further scope the potential for outsourcing this work and subject to the results of this scoping we will proceed to develop a business case for the external service delivery of this work in Q2 2014.

3.5 Registration System for Childcare Practitioners

The Early Years Education Policy Unit is co-located with the Department of Children and Youth Affairs (D/CYA) and acts in an advisory capacity on the qualifications that are considered appropriate for pre-school leaders delivering the universal free pre-school scheme. There are in the region of 22,000 people currently employed in the early year's sector. The D/CYA check qualifications manually, referring individual cases to the Early Years Education Policy Unit. The Childcare Directorate do not keep or maintain computerised records on early years practitioners working in early years settings or on decisions that have been made regarding the suitability of different qualifications. This Department has recently received a proposal developed in conjunction with the Department of Children and Youth Affairs to develop a professional registration system for childcare practitioners. Work to develop and maintain this proposed registration system could potentially be delivered by an external service provider. As a first step in assessing this proposal we will conduct a cost benefit analysis exercise of establishing a register in Q1 2014.

3.6 Administration and Funding of Special Education Schemes

The Department's Special Education Division in Athlone is responsible for the administration and funding of a number of special education schemes. The main schemes are:

i. Assistive Technology Scheme

The objective of the Assistive Technology scheme is to ensure that children with special educational needs have access to the equipment they need to enable them to benefit from the education system. The scheme provides funding for specialised equipment for

pupils with disabilities such as radio aids, brailers, computers and CCTVs for example, and the maintenance of such equipment. In 2012, 1,895 grants issued to schools for the purchase of special education equipment at a cost of €1.4m.

ii. Administration and funding of autism component of July provision

The July Provision scheme funds an extended school year or a home tuition programme for children who have been assessed as having a severe/ profound learning disability or autism. Four additional weeks tuition during July are provided in either a school-based programme or in the child's home. 5,570 pupils were supported under the July Provision Programme in the 2012/13 school year.

iii. Administration of the Home Tuition scheme

The Home Tuition scheme funds a home tuition programme for children who, for a number of reasons such as chronic illness, are unable to attend school. The scheme was extended in recent years to facilitate tuition for children awaiting an educational placement and provide early education intervention for pre-school children with autism. 1,249 pupils were supported under the scheme for the 2012/13 school year at an approximate cost of €9.3m.

There is potential to outsource the administration and funding of these schemes which would free up resources to focus on other core activities in the Special Education Division. In Q1 2014 we will further scope the potential for outsourcing this work and subject to the results of this scoping we will proceed to develop a business case for the external service delivery of this work in Q2 2014.

3.7 Payments in Schools

The Department is working with the Central Bank in relation to the schools element of the National Payments Plan. Schools are responsible for handling a huge range of incoming and outgoing payments, such as voluntary/administration fees, book rental schemes, school trips, etc. from parents. Cash and cheques appear to be the dominant way incoming payments in particular are made, despite the growth of alternative options in other countries (for example www.parentpay.co.uk in the UK). Teachers and administrative staff face a number of issues with organising these payments including administrative workload, cash security risk, reconciliation of payments and maintaining an audit trail. Many parents have expressed frustration that they can only make school payments by cash or cheque. The Department has recently facilitated the conduct of an online survey of schools by the Central Bank. The potential to use an external service delivery provider for payments will be considered in light of the findings from the survey.

4. Shared Services

In line with Government Policy, shared services models are core elements of the Education and Training Sector Reform Programme. A comprehensive Shared Services Plan for the Education and Training Sector for the period 2014 – 2016 is being finalised. This plan details shared services projects and procurement initiatives in a number of areas such as payroll, HR, Financial Management, ICT, Learning and Development, amongst others, across the education and training sector including the schools sector, SOLAS and the Education and Training Boards, the Further Education and Training Sector and the Higher Education Sector. Outsourcing of functions will be considered as part of the development of business cases for shared services projects.

5. Education and Training Sector External Service Delivery Plan 2014 – 2016

Initiative	Proposed Action	Start Date	Completion Date
Facilities Management	- Conduct audit of facilities management services currently outsourced across education and training sector. - We will identify priority areas for progression by end Q2 2014.	Q1 2014 Q2 2014	Q1 2014
Financial Control Checks on ESF	The potential to outsource of all of the financial checks required for the period 2014 – 2020 will be examined on receipt of the revised ESF cascade structure.	Q1 2014	
Inspectorate Questionnaires	- Scope the potential to outsource this work. - Subject to positive results of scoping proceed to develop business case.	Q1 2014 Q2 2014	Q1 2014 Q2 2014
Registration System for Childcare Practitioners	- Conduct cost benefit analysis of establishing register. - Subject to positive results proceed to develop business case.	Q1 2014 Q2 2014	Q1 2014 Q2 2014
Special Education Schemes	- Investigate the potential to outsource the administration and funding of these schemes. - Subject to positive results of proceed to develop business case.	Q1 2014 Q2 2014	Q1 2014 Q2 2014
Payments in Schools	The potential to outsource this work is being considered in the context of the Department's review of how payments are made in school.	Ongoing	

6. Human Resource Strategy

The future successful delivery of shared services and ESD projects may result in the freeing up of resources. The Education and Training Sector will use its business and workforce plans to address any human resource issues arising from the implementation of this external service delivery plan in line with the ECF and other Government initiatives.

APPENDIX 1 Bodies under the aegis of the Department

Aegis Body
Chomhairle um Oideachais Gaeltachta agus Gaelscolaíochta (COGG)
Commission to Inquire into Child Abuse (CICA)
Education Finance Board (EFB)
SOLAS
Education and Training Boards (ETBs)
Grangegorman Development Agency (GGDA)
Higher Education Authority (HEA)
Irish Research Council
Léargas - The Exchange Bureau
National Centre for Guidance in Education (NCGE)
National Council for Curriculum and Assessment (NCCA)
National Council for Special Education (NCSE)
Quality and Qualifications Ireland (QQI)
Residential Institutions Redress Board (RIRB)
Residential Institutions Review Committee (RIRC)
Residential Institutions Statutory Fund Board
Skillnets Ltd
State Examinations Commission (SEC)
The Teaching Council

APPENDIX 2 List of Out-Sourced Activities in the Education and Training Sector

Category	Includes
Archiving & Storage	
Contract Cleaning	
Debt Collection	
Education and Training services	Includes initiatives such as Momentum, SpringBoard, FÁS Training courses delivered in centre and through private providers
Employee Assistance Service for Teachers and SNAs	
Event Management	
Facilities Management	Including security, cleaning, water, canteen facilities, building maintenance, landscaping
ICT services	Including HEAnet (Ireland's National Education and Research network)
Irish Language Translations	
Internal Audit	
Laboratory Services	
Professional services	Including legal, architect, engineering, compliance audits on school building projects
Major construction projects	
Minor works	
Media monitoring	
Parking	
Printing Services	
Recruitment	
Staff Training	
Student Services	Including CAO and SUSI
Waste Collection	Recycling Services, Shredding
Web Design and Webcasting	

